



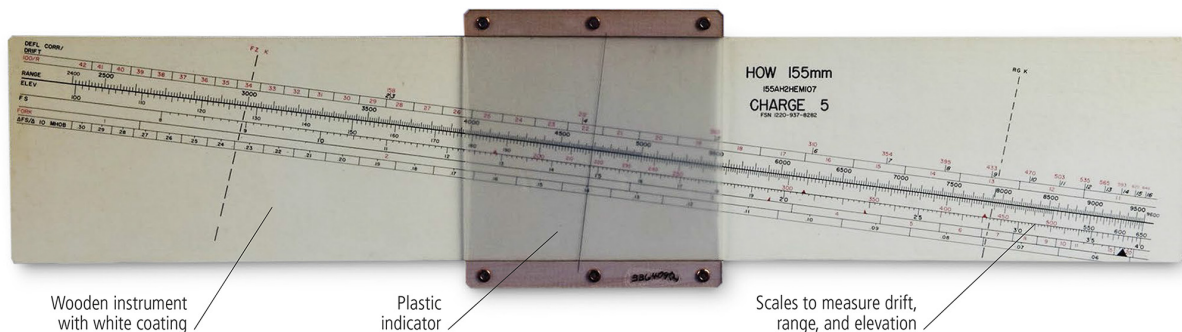
First wounded

Men of the First Air Cavalry Division rest and receive medical care 3 miles (5 km) north of the Ia Drang Valley in November 1965. The weary men had survived an ambush, and had spent all day and night in intense firefights.

Drawing conclusions

The battle was significant for many other reasons. It was also the first major encounter between US and NVA regular forces, and the battle established a template for the remainder of the war. The US would rely on superior technology and firepower to inflict heavy losses on their foe, who would withdraw when fighting was no longer prudent. The North Vietnamese also learned that the best way to blunt the effectiveness of US artillery and airpower during battle was to keep close contact with American units so that airstrikes could only be used at the risk of friendly fire.

Both sides declared victory—the US for suffering fewer casualties and achieving a territorial objective, and the NVA for standing up to US forces and surviving to fight again. US forces eventually withdrew from the area and returned to their bases, allowing the NVA to resume operations.



Measuring attacks

This graphical firing table, made in Chicago in 1960, was used to position a 155 mm howitzer armed with M107 shells. It allowed soldiers in the field to calibrate the range, angle, and fuse setting of artillery pieces to hit the enemy target.